

The microphone is open

There was a time when starting a media property required a printing press, a television studio, a radio licence, or at least a suspiciously large amount of somebody else's money. Today, you can begin one with a phone, a quiet room, and the dangerous belief that people might actually want to hear what you have to say.

That sounds flippant until you look at the numbers.

India had 177 million monthly podcast listeners in 2024, according to PwC, up from 154 million just a year earlier. By 2029, that audience is expected to reach 267 million, growing at 8.5 percent annually. Podcast advertising revenue, meanwhile, was a little over \$39 million in 2024 and is projected to exceed \$57 million by 2029. In other words, the audience is already enormous, the money is still catching up, and the gap between the two is where opportunity tends to live. More importantly, these are no longer fringe numbers belonging to a tiny enthusiast community. Podcasting in India is already a mass-media behaviour, even if its economics still look relatively young.

There is another reason this moment feels different. Podcasts have escaped the headphone.

YouTube says more than one billion people worldwide now watch or listen to podcast content on the platform every month. In April 2026 alone, YouTube Premium subscribers watched more than 800 million hours of podcasts. Spotify says more than 500 million of its users have streamed a video podcast, a figure that has grown by nearly 50 percent year-on-year. The thing we continue to call a "podcast" is quietly becoming a format that can be listened to on the Metro, watched on a television, clipped into a Reel, quoted in a newsletter, searched through a transcript and discovered through an algorithm.

That is not the death of audio. It is audio getting more doors.

India makes those doors particularly interesting. PwC estimates that the country's wider music, radio and podcast market grew from \$438 million in 2020 to \$1 billion in 2024. At the same time, India's creator economy has exploded: the number of influencers grew from fewer than one million in 2020 to more than four million in 2024. Suddenly, the person across

the microphone does not have to be a movie star. A founder, gamer, doctor, historian, teacher, comedian, lawyer, engineer or obsessive biryani researcher can arrive with an audience, expertise or both.

Then there is language. The IAMAI-Kantar Internet in India report found that 870 million internet users accessed the internet in Indic languages in 2024, while 57 percent of urban internet users said they preferred accessing internet content in Indic languages. Video was the leading Indic-language online activity, used by 81 percent of these users. For podcasting, that is not merely a statistic about translation. It is permission to stop assuming that serious, ambitious digital publishing must default to English.

Spotify offers a useful hint of what that can mean. More than 200,000 podcasts were created using its tools in India during 2023, while listening grew across history, education, mythology and true crime. Four of Spotify India's top ten podcasts that year belonged to mythology or spirituality, with the category growing by more than 80 percent.

So, yes, everyone appears to have a podcast now. Your colleague has one. Your favourite YouTuber has three. Someone you went to school with is interviewing startup founders beneath a neon sign.

That does not mean the opportunity has passed. It means the lazy opportunity most definitely has.

Owning a microphone is no longer remarkable. Having something worth returning to is. The real advantage now comes from clarity, consistency, curiosity, production discipline and an ability to understand one audience better than a thousand competitors attempting to speak to everybody.

And perhaps that is why podcasting remains so appealing. The barriers to entry have collapsed, but the rewards still favour craft. You can start cheaply, improve visibly, build slowly and reach people without asking a gatekeeper for a slot on their schedule.

The microphone has never been easier to switch on. Getting someone to come back for episode two is where the real work begins. **d**